



Supermarine Spitfire

Arguably the most famous aircraft of all time, the iconic Spitfire was instrumental—along with the Hawker Hurricane—in defending Britain during the Battle of Britain in 1940. More prominent than the Hurricane because of its instantly recognizable, curvaceous lines, the Spitfire was a wartime propagandist's dream. Its basic design lent itself to continuous development and it remained in production from the beginning to the end of World War II.

DESIGNED BY R. J. MITCHELL, creator of Supermarine's Schneider Trophy-winning racing floatplanes of the 1920s and early 1930s, the Spitfire fighter epitomized elegant stressed-skin construction. In contrast to a fabric covering over wood or metal frames, an eggshell-thin, aluminum-alloy outer surface carried much of the load imposed on the aircraft.

The beautiful elliptical wing shape was chosen not for its looks but because it offered low drag while still allowing room for the retracted undercarriage and eight 0.303-in Browning machine guns (later a combination of guns and 20-mm cannon).

The type's potential for development meant that by the time Mitchell's successor Joseph Smith had produced the final variant in 1946—the Mk24—it had more than twice the horsepower of the prototype, and its maximum weight had increased by the equivalent of 30 passengers.



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